year round instead of just the weeks before a new play was staged. During my junior year, she took it upon herself to get Eureka invited to a prestigious one-act play contest at Northwestern University.

For college actors, the competition was comparable to the Super Bowl. Hundreds of colleges around the country, including all the big schools—Princeton, Yale, and so forth—competed for invitations to bring student actors to the competition. I never learned how Miss Johnson pulled it off, but she wangled an invitation for tiny, 250-student Eureka College, the only school accepted that year that didn't have a full-time dramatic arts department.

For our entry, she selected *Aria da Capo*, a one-act play by Edna St. Vincent Millay that was set in ancient Greece and had an antiwar theme. I played a shepherd strangled before the final curtain by Bud Cole, my football teammate, fraternity brother, and one of my best friends. Death scenes are always pleasant for an actor and I tried to play it to the hilt.

To our delight, Eureka placed second in the competition and while we were relishing this success, it was announced I was one of three performers who had been selected to receive individual acting awards. Afterward, the head of Northwestern's Speech Department, the sponsor of the contest, called me into his office and inquired if I'd ever thought about making acting my career.

I said, "Well, no," and he said, "Well, you should." It was quite a thrill for a young man trying to set the course of his life.

I guess that was the day the acting bug really bit me, although I think it was probably orbiting pretty close to me for a long time before that, even before *Journey's End* and my student plays at Dixon High.

After we moved to Dixon, I fell in love with the movies. I couldn't count the number of hours I spent in the darkness